FRANCES & KEVIN

FREE GUIDE

Marketing Your Small Business in the UK

A practical guide to strategy, channels, budgets, and building a plan that works.

01 Positioning before channels
02 Choosing the right channels
03 Writing a 12-month plan
04 Setting a marketing budget
05 Capturing and nurturing leads
06 When to get help

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INTRODUCTION

Why Most UK Business Marketing Fails

Most small business marketing fails not because of budget or effort, but because there is no underlying strategy connecting the activity. You post on social media, try a few ads, occasionally send an email newsletter, and then wonder why growth is inconsistent. The problem is almost never the tactics. It is the absence of a plan.

This guide covers how to approach marketing your small business in a way that compounds over time, rather than producing occasional results that are difficult to repeat or explain. It is written for UK business owners. Every section focuses on decisions and actions, not frameworks for their own sake.

What this guide covers

01 **Positioning before channels**
The foundation everything else is built on.

02 **Choosing the right channels**
Pick two or three. Be excellent, not mediocre.

03 **Writing a 12-month plan**
A simple structure you will actually use.

04 **Setting a marketing budget**
How to allocate spend at your stage of growth.

05 **Capturing and nurturing leads**
Converting interest into customers over time.

06 **When to get help**
Agency, freelancer, or in-house — how to decide.

SECTION 01

Positioning Before Channels

The most common mistake small business owners make is starting with the question "which channels should I be on?" The right question is: who are my best customers, and what makes me the obvious choice for them?

Why positioning comes first

Positioning is the foundation everything else is built on. If you cannot clearly and specifically articulate who you help, with what, and why you are better suited than your competitors, no channel will work as well as it should. Your social media posts will be vague. Your website will lack conviction. Your ads will have weak conversion rates.

Three questions to answer before you pick a channel

Be specific with your answers:

- Who is your single best type of customer? Not everyone. The specific type where the value is highest, the relationship is best, and referrals are most likely.
- What specific problem do you solve for them? Not a list of services. The specific outcome they care most about.
- Why would they choose you over a competitor? Not "we are friendly and professional." The actual commercial reason a rational buyer would pick you.

Key principle

When you can answer all three clearly and specifically, your marketing becomes significantly easier to produce and significantly more effective.

SECTION 02

Choosing the Right Channels

One of the most reliable ways to make your marketing ineffective is to spread it across too many channels. Every channel requires content, consistency, and time to compound. A business excellent on two channels outperforms one half-heartedly present on eight.

Channels that work for most UK businesses

• Google Search and your website. When someone searches for a solution, appearing in those results is the highest-intent marketing available. Requires a well-structured site and basic SEO.

• Google Business Profile. Essential for any business with a local or regional market. It is free, drives real enquiries, and most businesses have not optimised it properly.

• LinkedIn. The strongest channel for B2B businesses and professional services. A consistent presence from the business owner generates more high-quality relationships than most ad budgets.

• Email. Significantly underused by most small businesses. A list of opted-in contacts is the most valuable marketing asset you can build. Costs nothing to use. Converts better than social media.

The rule

Choose two or three channels. Commit to being excellent on them. Ignore the rest until you have the capacity to expand properly.

SECTION 03

Writing a 12-Month Plan

The difference between a business that markets consistently and one that markets reactively is almost always a written plan. It does not need to be complex. It needs to answer four questions.

Four questions every marketing plan must answer

- What are we trying to achieve commercially in the next 12 months? Revenue targets, customer numbers, new markets — the commercial goal drives everything else.
- Which channels and activities will we focus on? Be specific. Not "social media" — LinkedIn three times per week, one article per month, a monthly email to our list.
- What is the budget and how is it allocated? Even a rough split helps. Paid vs owned vs earned.
- How will we measure whether it is working? Pick two or three metrics that connect directly to the commercial goal. Avoid vanity metrics.

Why it matters

When you have those four questions answered and documented, your marketing stops being reactive. You start executing a plan with a clear purpose.

SECTION 04

Setting a Marketing Budget

One of the most common questions from UK business owners is how much to spend on marketing. There is no single right answer, but sensible frameworks help you make a rational decision rather than an arbitrary one.

How UK businesses typically approach this

B2C businesses typically spend 5 to 10 percent of revenue on marketing. B2B businesses typically spend 2 to 5 percent. Faster-growing businesses spend more. Established businesses with strong referrals spend less.

How to allocate your budget across three buckets

- Owned — your website, email list, content. Investment here builds long-term compounding value.
- Paid — ads, sponsored content, paid directories. Generates faster results but stops when you stop spending.
- Earned — PR, referrals, partnerships. The most cost-effective but hardest to control.

Starting point

Allocate the majority of your budget to owned and earned channels first. Add paid spend selectively once you know which messages and offers resonate.

SECTION 05

Capturing and Nurturing Leads

Most small business marketing drives people to a website or social profile and then loses them. They view the content, they do not immediately buy, and they never return. The gap is a mechanism for capturing the relationship before they are ready to purchase.

What a lead nurturing system looks like

An email newsletter, a lead magnet, a free consultation, or a useful download gives people a reason to share their contact details before they are ready to buy. A consistent email programme keeps you visible until the moment they are ready.

Simple steps to build it

- Create one piece of genuinely useful content — a guide, checklist, or template — that your best customers would want.
- Build a simple landing page with a form to capture name and email in exchange for the download.
- Write a short blog post about the resource and link to the landing page.
- Set up a short welcome email sequence — three to five emails over two weeks — that introduces your business and provides value.
- Send a useful email to your list at least once per month.

The businesses that grow most consistently
are usually the ones with the strongest lead nurturing processes, not the ones with the biggest advertising budgets.

SECTION 06

When to Get Help

There is a point in every growing business where the owner's time is better spent on the business than on the marketing. The question of whether to bring in an agency, freelancer, or in-house hire is one of the most important commercial decisions you will make.

Agency, freelancer, or in-house?

The right answer depends on your stage, budget, and what you are trying to achieve:

- Agency. Best when you need a broad range of skills, can afford the fees, and have a clear brief. They perform best when the client understands their own marketing well enough to direct the work.
- Freelancer. Best when you have a specific and defined need — SEO, copywriting, social media — and want flexibility and lower overhead.
- In-house. Best when marketing is a core function and you want someone fully embedded in your team and culture.

Before you make that decision

Make sure you understand your own marketing well enough to direct whoever you bring in. An owner who cannot articulate what they want will always get less value from external support.

Ready to go further?

This guide gives you a clear starting point. If you want structured support, the Frances & Kevin Marketing for Business Owners programme takes you through the full process over five weeks, live online, with a finished 12-month marketing plan as the output.

The programme is CPD-accredited, taught by an FCIM-qualified marketer, and designed around the real constraints of running a growing business.

Course	Format	Investment
Marketing for Business Owners	5 weeks, live online	**£399**
Marketing Leadership Programme	7 weeks, live online	**£799**
SOSTAC® Planning Masterclasses	2 sessions, live online	**£595**

Visit **francesandkevin.co.uk** to view all courses and enrol. Or email james@francesandkevin.co.uk to talk it through first.

Frances & Kevin is a CPD-accredited marketing training provider based in Cheadle Hulme, Stockport.